

Sandisk Extreme Pro

Sandisk's new Extreme Pro CF cards store up to 64 GB of data and write at a speed of 90 MBps

Sony HDR-TG1

Sony's HDR-TG1 is the world's smallest full HD camcorder

Digital Camera Test

Typically, people who want to do wildlife photography. Built rather well, use of metal zoom trigger would be nice.

It has inherited most of the features from the standard H series from Sony. The camera has a hinge screen that works well but only for vertical movement. There is no swivel to fold the screen back on its face.

The recording supports stereo audio recording and the microphone is placed on the top of the camera. The jog dial is a feature found on DSLRs but its also found on ultrazoom cameras. It can be used for manual control as well. The jog dial also doubles as a button. All these functions bundled together for use with these controls make it simpler even in the manual shooting mode.

The 20x optical zoom requires a very good image stabilizing feature and the DSC HX1 does a decent job. It works particularly well up to 8x to 10x but any more than that and there's a lot of delay added which makes even pointing to a distant object a little difficult.

Sony includes a couple of unique features that merit mention. For example, the smile and face detection feature can shoot photos depending on the intensity of the smile. There's actually a manual setting you can turn on for that.

The other impressive feature is the video recording resolution of 1440 x 1080 pixels. Video quality is decent but not very nice in low-light. Other than that, the Sony proprietary connector to the camera is something that's very irritating. A microUSB interface would've been convenient. An adapter is provided to allow HDMI connectivity. Sony continues to use MemoryStick as the storage format. They're a little more expensive than the more commonly used SD and SDHC cards.

The Sony DSC-HX1 is priced at Rs. 29,990 and because, it had to be sent back urgently to Sony, it couldn't be part of the complete test process.

Canon PowerShot SX200 IS

Canon's PowerShot SX1xx IS cameras impressed everyone and we've also looked at the SX120 IS in this test. The camera is pretty good with just a few tiny improvements over the last two models. The SX200 IS is a better design than the SX120 and features a 12x optical zoom – pretty neat for its size.



Canon PowerShot SX200 IS

One end of the body has a slight curve, this is where you grip the camera and gives the mock impression of a wider grip. It also feels bulkier for some reason and sturdier than the SX120. The control dial at the back could've been built better. The other buttons have a good tactile feel.

The side door is huge and has the USB and HDMI connectors there. The door itself is held together by a frail and flexible plastic hinge. One of the unique and also somewhat irritating features is the flash unit which pops out the same time the lens does. It sticks out the top of the camera by a folding hinge mechanism and does come in the way while holding the camera with your left hand. There is no way to fold the flash unit back in other than to turn off the camera. One of the sides has a chrome-finish and that goes well with the colour and shape of the camera.

Nikon COOLPIX P90

The Nikon COOLPIX P90 is a prosumer camera or alternatively can also be called an ultrazoom camera.

The P90 has the largest zoom we've seen so far – 24X optical zoom (4.0 – 110.4mm). Like the Fujifilm Finepix S1500, this too has a good handgrip. The buttons are all of very good quality.

The screen hinge design is very similar to the Sony DSC-HX1 and only allows vertical movement. The user interface looks very similar to the ones found on Nikon DSLRs. It is very functional and lacks the

over-user-friendliness seen on cameras of some other brands. The zoom trigger brings up a help menu when you use it in any of the camera settings menus. Lithium-ion batteries are used so most of the weight is the camera itself. The jog dial is built well just like on Nikon's DSLR cameras. It isn't used to control the manual focussing though.

One of the unique features we've seen is the ISO sensitivity range which can be capped. The camera then will not cross that limit so you never end up with very grainy images. Video recording resolution is rather basic on the P90 whereas most of the ultrazoom cameras are aiming at the basic HD standard – 720p.

There are some modes where custom user settings can be stored. There are also modes which change the aspect ratio of the image to fit TV screens.

Operation of the huge zoom is silent although there is some fine vibration. Image stabilization at maximum zoom isn't too bad either. It's very usable but a better quality lens would've really made this shine. At maximum zoom, there's some quality loss. There's a little bit of yellow colouration on the screen after the photo has been captured. On a computer screen though, the result looks natural. The colours are sober and there is no overemphasis of colours.

There's little to hate about the Nikon P90. It's a great overall camera that now moves Nikon closer to the ultrazoom camera market at least in India. So far, it's been Canon and Sony that have mostly dominated this area. A little more of quality and performance and this camera could've been a winner.

Nikon COOLPIX S220

The Nikon P90 might have one of the largest optical zooms but the S220 is one of the smallest cameras around.

It comes in really bright colours – we got a dark pink one. It only has 3x optical



Nikon COOLPIX P90